INDIA PAKISTAN WAR

The Digital Frontier

Deepfakes, bots and troll farms emerge as a new weapon in the India-Pakistan conflict

By **Pradip R. Sagar and Anilesh S. Mahajan**



ON **May 7, after India struck terrorist infrastructure inside Pakistan,** Islamabad responded by lifting a 15-month-old ban on X (formerly Twitter). Though the Pakistan military's official handle remained dormant, affiliated proxies sprang into action. A deepfake video of Indian external affairs minister S. Jaishankar appearing to apologise for the strikes went viral. The Fact Check Unit of India's Press Information Bureau (PIB) quickly debunked it. In a counter-strike of sorts, another clip went viral, showing Pakistan military spokesperson Lt General Ahmed Sharif Chaudhry admitting the loss of their two JF-17 jets—shared nearly 700,000 times on X before it was exposed as a fabrication by the media watchdog Bellingcat.

The battle during Operation Sindoor wasn't fought solely with fighter jets, missiles and drones. It raged just as fiercely in the digital domain—a parallel war, where deepfakes, fake advisories, doctored videos and coordinated propaganda flooded timelines. In this cognitive battlefield, perceptions—not just positions—were under siege. And truth was often the first casualty.

India, with over 500 million social media users, became both a megaphone for misinformation and a force for rebuttal. Crowdsourced fact-checking sometimes outpaced official communication. Yet, in this AI-fuelled information war, troll farms and unsuspecting users frequently countered one falsehood with another. From recycled war clips to AI-generated statements by top officials, platforms like X, Instagram, Facebook and TikTok (banned in India) turned into digital trenches.

While the tools were cutting-edge, the concept was ancient—what the Chinese military strategist Sun Tzu called "subduing the enemy without fighting", a core principle in his 5th century BC treatise *The Art of War*. The modern equivalent is cognitive warfare—manipulating narratives to influence audiences, with social media acting as a powerful tool.

WEAPONISING THE FEED

Misattributed visuals surged online. Footage from the Israel-Gaza conflict was rebranded as fresh Indian air strikes. Old Indian Air Force (IAF) crash videos resurfaced as proof of Pakistani retaliation. Claims of multiple blasts at an air base in Jammu were accompanied by an image from the 2021 Kabul airport attack. A wildfire was pitched as a Pakistani missile strike on a military base in Amritsar.

By May 11, the I&B ministry had issued over 20 official clarifications, warning of "Pakistan-linked accounts" trying to "flood the information space with falsehoods"